

New German transport minister's overflowing in tray

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-07-28 14:02

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SNEAK PEEK

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— Ships that pay a toll to Iranian authorities for safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz risk having their insurance voided, as the U.K. and U.S. gear to discuss protecting maritime traffic in the critical waterway.

— Aircraft engine manufacturers and technology companies are investing in artificial intelligence tools to transform the maintenance, repair and overhaul of airliners.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

GERMANY'S TRANSPORT REVOLUTION: Steffen Bilger will become Germany's transport minister after Chancellor Friedrich Merz reshuffled his Cabinet, putting a new face in charge of Europe's largest transport network as Berlin races to modernize its rail, road and bridge infrastructure.

Why it matters: Europe's largest economy sits at the heart of the continent's transport network, and years of underinvestment have left Germany's aging railways, roads and bridges a major bottleneck for passenger and freight traffic across the EU. Berlin is also expected to play a central role in rolling out infrastructure investments and improving military mobility.

Merz's mission: Without explaining why Schnieder was dismissed, the chancellor said on Monday that Bilger had been tasked with rapidly delivering infrastructure projects to justify the government's unprecedented borrowing program. "My expectation of the federal transport minister is the rapid implementation of transport projects — rail, road and the entire infrastructure," Merz said, adding he was confident Bilger could deliver.

A familiar face: Bilger is no newcomer to the ministry. He served as transport state secretary between 2018 and 2021, overseeing digital infrastructure and acting as the federal government's coordinator for freight transport and logistics. A CDU lawmaker from carmaking powerhouse Baden-Württemberg, he is expected to be appointed on an interim basis next week before formally taking office when the Bundestag returns in September.

MARITIME

HORMUZ STRAIT JACKET: Ships that pay a toll to Iranian authorities for safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz risk having their insurance voided under a new clause drawn up for the Lloyd's market, our colleague Sophie Inge reports, as the U.K. and U.S. try to pin down a date for a summit to discuss protecting maritime traffic in the critical waterway.

What this means in practice: In guidance published Friday, the Lloyd's Market Association, which represents underwriters, said insurers will not cover the cost of any fee paid by vessels passing through the strait — which is a global chokepoint for the trade of crude oil and liquefied natural gas. If any such payment is made, it warned that insurance cover would cease due to the risk of breaching sanctions or terrorism legislation in the U.K., U.S. and EU.

Managing mounting risk: "Insurance has taken center stage of global geopolitics, and the sector is scrambling to manage this mounting risk exposure," Gonzalo Saiz, a research fellow at the Royal United Services Institute's Centre for Finance and Security, told MTUK. "The LMA clauses are often creative ways of responding to the fast-evolving risk landscape, be it war or sanctions risk."

Blocs' position: While Britain has not formally proscribed Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) as a terrorist organization, support for the military group is banned and it remains sanctioned under U.K. law. Iranian government departments, such as the Ministry of Defence, are also subject to sanctions. The U.S. and EU, meanwhile, have taken a more hard-line position, with both designating the IRGC as a terrorist organization, in addition to imposing sanctions.

METSAF BULLETIN: The Commission approved measures by Italy and Spain to relieve their road and maritime transport sector respectively under the Middle East Crisis Temporary State Aid Framework (METSAF).

Italy will be able to offer tax credits for up to a total of €300 million to road transport companies suffering additional fuel costs resulting from the Middle East crisis.

Spain got clearance to spend €74 million in direct grants for companies operating specific maritime routes connecting mainland Spain with the non-peninsular territories of Ceuta and Melilla, the Balearic Islands and the Canary Islands, as well as certain inter-island routes.

AVIATION

AI ENTERS AIRCRAFT MAINTENANCE: Engine manufacturers and technology companies are increasingly betting on artificial intelligence to transform aircraft maintenance, repair and overhaul, or MRO, as airlines grapple with rising maintenance costs in the post-pandemic era. That's one of the key — if not entirely unexpected — trends emerging from last week's Farnborough International Airshow.

An aging fleet — the result of aircraft demand outstripping supply, a well-known issue we've covered before — is also driving interest in AI applications for civil aviation. The EU Aviation Safety Agency has long identified AI as a promising tool for both managing maintenance data and enabling predictive

maintenance to prevent failures.

Pressure is on: "Our operators are under tremendous pressure to reduce disruptions and increase reliability to ensure we can handle this continued growth in air travel," said Nicole White, general manager of connected aviation at RTX's Collins Aerospace. "Predictive maintenance has matured," White told Tommaso.

What's available? Collins Aerospace launched its Ascentia platform in 2025. It "analyzes maintenance history, pilot reports, technician write-ups, and it's looking for recurring maintenance events that may indicate an underlying issue on [a] system or component" with the ultimate goal "to recommend corrective actions," White added.

What's next? By the end of the year, Collins plans to launch a second AI-powered tool designed to minimize the time aircraft spend on the ground for maintenance by analyzing operational and maintenance data.

Spotting false alarms: During a recent trial, the new system identified that a component that was repeatedly removed and sent for repair because of recurring alerts was not actually faulty. Instead, "there was a vibration coming from somewhere else in the system ... that was causing it to trigger alerts to get pulled," White said.

Not stealing jobs: "The intent of these tools isn't meant to be replacing the technician," White said, responding to a question about whether AI could reduce maintenance staffing. "We're trying to bring our OEM [or original equipment manufacturer] knowledge and expertise and really just help them strengthen and not replace their existing operations."

Rivals from the tech sector: Aircraft manufacturers are not the only companies targeting this market. Technology group Capgemini presented Maestro at Farnborough, describing it as "an AI orchestrator for aerospace and defense dedicated to MRO and services," said Frédéric Combes, the company's global aerospace and defence industry leader.

What can it do? Combes said the system can detect a problem, "then analyzing with the record what could be the maintenance action to do and then ... send to the operator or maintenance engineer which is on the aircraft what is exactly the task he needs to do."

Those tasks are typically split today among several specialists within an airline, from spare-parts logistics teams to maintenance engineers. Maestro instead acts as "expert and knowledgeable both on the technical analysis and the supply chain management in order to be capable to apply and work as per the processes of the concerned client," Combes told Tommaso.

CHARLEROI AIRPORT TO SUSPEND FLIGHTS IN 2028: Brussels South Charleroi Airport (BSCA) confirmed Monday that it will suspend flight operations in the second half of 2028 to allow major runway reconstruction and infrastructure upgrades. Over the weekend, Belgian trade union SETCa criticized the Walloon regional government for lacking a clear strategy for the airport and voiced concerns that traffic may not return to pre-closure levels once operations resume.

What's the plan? "A complete refurbishment of Charleroi Airport's sole runway (which has an estimated lifespan of 25 years), together with other major infrastructure modernisation works, has been scheduled by SOWAER for the second half of 2028," the airport told us. SOWAER is the Walloon public company that manages the airport's infrastructure.

Down to earth: "To minimise the overall duration of the disruption, the various construction projects will be carried out simultaneously," the airport added, noting that "this will require a temporary suspension of air traffic during the works." The disruption will reportedly last for months.

A necessary investment: Walloon Airports Minister Cécile Neven told Belgian media that the renovation had been planned for years and was necessary to safeguard the airport's safety, performance and long-term competitiveness.

CARS

PORSCHE DOUBLES DOWN ON JOB CUTS: Porsche will eliminate another 5,000 jobs by 2035, bringing the total number of positions lost under its restructuring to 8,900, our colleague Ferdinand Knapp reports. The company said the reductions will be achieved through natural attrition and retirements, while maintaining its employment guarantee and ruling out compulsory redundancies until 2035.

€2.1B investment: The move, which Porsche calls its "Future Package," follows media reports earlier this month that the carmaker was planning to cut around 4,000 jobs. At the same time, Porsche announced plans to invest €2.1 billion in its production sites in Stuttgart-Zuffenhausen and Weissach.

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